Transgender Reflections (A Collection)

By Alex Peach, Sam Rush, Ethan Smith and Miles Walser

Sticks and Stones by Alex Peach

Sticks and stones may break my bones but words will never hurt me.

Bones can heal. Scratches, grazes, even gunshot wounds, they can heal. But the scars on the inside, the ones that no one can see — the words swirling around in people's heads, ripping their insides out — those hurt. Those create scars.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Alex Peach
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Website: https://thinkqueerly.com/sticks-and-stones-fa6d3161d8cc

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INTRODUCTION

According to the Human Rights Campaign, in 2021, state legislatures have introduced more than 100 bills that aim to curb the rights of transgender people across the country. From bathroom bans to youth sports restrictions – most of these bills affect transgender youth, a group that researchers and medical professionals warn is already susceptible to high rates of suicide and depression.

It seems that our country is devolving into a system of labels to define and isolate. When the truth of the matter is: every person in our society has value and every person should be treated with respect. "He/his; she/her or even they/them" – even these small words are important.

In this collection, Transgender Reflections, Alex Peach, Sam Rush, Ethan Smith and Miles Walser raise their voices to illuminate the person behind the label – people who are transgender are people first.

Neverland by Sam Rush

When I was a little boy, I played Peter
and rescued Wendy from Captian Hook and the crocodile's
tick, tick, tick.
Meanwhile, the swallowed clock in my abdomen
counted down minutes 'til my insides would betray me.

I carved symbols of manhood into never land trees,
symbols I could never carve quite deep enough into me,
and prayed my bark would scar quick.

When I was a little boy I played Peter.
Peter always dressed in clothes made out of
leaves. Lost boys!
Little lost boys! Follow me!
Little lost boys dressed in the skins of the things they killed,
filled the forest with dancing little lots boy half-breeds.

When I was a little boy I learned little girls were pretty,
like lanterns, but not to be placed on the ground,
except when stronger light by house fire was needed,
having half-lives, at best.
I learned little girls in love thought less, and less clearly
that a glint in the eye was a chance,
an opportunity.
I learned elephants in your bedroom could
swallow secrets without first asking to sit on your chest.

When I was a little boy, I knew time would one day
grow the weakness inside of me into blooming rot

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and I would wake up seeping.
See when I was a little boy, I played Peter, I played Peter,
but should have known it could only ever be make-believe.
I could only ever be "Little lost boys! Lost boys? Follow
me!"
I could only ever be Little Lost Boy dressed in the skins of
others,
I could only ever behalf-breed,
'cause when I was a little boy, I felt shrapnel hit daily
at this woman I would one day grow into being.

I have spent years clawing pieces from this body
I have fought to wake up seeing attached
to fingers I clawed freedom from and dug ditches with
and threw pitches out of.

When I was a little boy, I had little boy mouth and little boy
teeth and little boy tongue.
I could little boy speak, but never learned how to hide my
little boy eyes
from all that's lost when little boys see,
like how little talk there is to little boys
about the kind of strong little girls have to be.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sam Rush
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A Letter to the Girl I Used to Be
by Ethan Smith

Dear Emily,

Every time I watch baseball, a voice I no longer recognize
whispers,

"Ethan, do you remember? When you were gonna be the
first girl

To play in the major leagues? Seattle Mariners. Rally cap."

But to be honest, Emily, I don't.

Dad told me that like it was someone else's bedtime story.

But I do know you had that drive,

Didn't let anyone tell you to wear shorts above your knees,

Didn't care if boys thought your hair fell on your shoulders
just right.

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But with girls, sleepovers meant the space between your
shoulder and hers

Was a six-inch fatal territory.

The year you turned eleven

Was the first time you said out loud that you didn't want to
live anymore.

In therapy, you said you wouldn't make it to 21.

On my 21st birthday, I thought about you;

You were right.

At nineteen, you started to fade.

I tried to cross you out, like a line in my memoir

I wished I could erase completely.

And maybe I'm misunderstanding the definition of death,

But even though parts of you still exist,

You are not here.

Most of my friends have never heard your name until now.

I've been trying to write this letter for six months.

I still can't decide if it should be an apology or not.

But now you will never hear "Emily Smith" announced at a
college graduation,

Get married, give birth.

When the prescribed testosterone started taking effect,
My body stopped producing the potential for new life every month.
I thought about your children, how I wanted them, too.
I let a doctor remove your breasts so that I could stand up straighter.
Now even if I somehow had those children, I wouldn't be able to nourish them.
My body is obsolete,
Scarred cosmetic, but never C-section.
I was four days late;
They will never be grandparents.
I was one week late;
They will never hold their lover's sleeping figure.
I was eleven days late;
They will never breathe in a sunset and sunrise in the same night.
I was two weeks late;
They will never learn to jump rope.
I was three weeks late;
They will never shout, "Watch, Mommy! Watch me on the slide!"

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I was two months late;
A piece of us will never wrap their arms around our leg for comfort,
Or just to keep them from falling down.
And I am . . . sorry that this process is so slow, and all you can do is wonder if you ever had a place.
You did.
You still do.
Don't forget that.

Yours, Ethan

P.S. I never hated you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ethan Smith
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Website: https://everydayfeminism.com/2016/02/letter-to-girl-i-used-to-be/

Lillian by Miles Walser

I will name you Lillian
because to me it sounds like running through a garden
and with every step you take in life I want you to feel as beautiful as the flower I'll call you.
And don't worry about your mother:
whenever I meet her, I'll convince her I deserve naming rights.
But more importantly, Lillian, you will inherit from me the one thing
the world will let me give you.
I can't hand you my curly hair or blue eyes,
so you will have the name that has followed me
from birth certificate to driver's license to passport,
all the while knowing it was never really mine.
Your middle name will be Olivia.
For years I hated the name;
it burned through the paper of any official document I filled out,
seared my ears when it escaped the tongue of a stranger,

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and annihilated my entire body anytime I had to incorrectly introduce myself.
But Lillian, I understand what happened now.
See, I am just the middleman; the accidental address on the package.
The name was given to me, to hold onto for you,
my future daughter.
For you I keep it safe, protected from people who gawk at me,
not understanding why my short hair and masculine appearance
can't match the sweet femininity in the name.
Or people who do understand and hate me for it,
attacking the way I bypass the barrier of biological sex
because I know that what I feel is more important than what I see in the mirror.
And people who think I should conform to the name I was given,
ignoring everything I know about myself,
the same people who will someday hate our family because of me.

But through it all, Lillian, always remember that I love you.

I've never met you,

but I love you.

My future daughter.

So I hold the name under my shirt, against my chest,

and with every heartbeat the syllables provide me a new

sense of rhythmic direction.

Because I know I'm moving towards you.

The name Olivia no longer hides in the back of my throat

but floats off my tongue.

A promise of beauty; a promise of purpose. A promise of

you,

my future daughter.

Someday, Lillian Olivia, after you've mastered the art of the

two-wheeled bike,

I'll take you to the top of the tallest hill in town and we'll

soar down,

secretly wishing we could take off into the rushing wind

and at the bottom I'll tell you that

that feeling was how your father felt,

knowing someday, you'd be in his world.

And he'd finally get to give you your name.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier
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